Challenge 5: A Hindu Party? The Hindu–Muslim Question and the Future of Secularism

The fifth political risk for the BJP is the possibility of increased social strife if it goes further down the route of Hindu identity-based ethnic politics. During his address in Ayodhya in 2020, Modi signalled a dialling down of temperature on the Hindu card after the BJP won the political battle on Ram, but the party has enough absolutist hardliners on religious issues. The social forces unleashed by Hindu triumphalism may also prove to be beyond the party's control. For example, by early 2020, the Karnataka BJP's Twitter handle had started pushing out such divisive messaging on CAA that some of the old guard in the party were uncomfortable. As one told me, 'This is immature. This kind of messaging affects only a few thousand people. People are mature now. They don't associate with this.' Flexing saffron muscles often works to the BJP's advantage in polarised areas, but some party leaders also saw the need to keep this tendency in check.

Even at a time when the new love jihad laws in BJP-ruled states have added a fresh twist to the debates on personal freedoms and religion, the central question for the party is an old one, and Vajpayee had raised it in 1991. Does the BJP see itself as a religious party or as a political party with a Hindu cultural tint? 'There are elements who would like to see the BJP become a religious party,' said Vajpayee. He was responding to the debate generated by the slogan '*Jo Hindu Hit Mein Baat Karega, Vahi Desh Pe Raj Karega*' (Only he who speaks in the Hindu interest will rule the country). Both Advani and Vajpayee objected to the slogan at a BJP plenary session that year. The next day, another slogan was raised, '*Jo Rashtra Hit Mein Baat Karega, Vahi Desh Pe Raj Karega*', in which 'Hindu interest' was replaced by 'national interest'.[69]

The big question is whether the BJP can reconstitute itself as a right-wing party that respects tradition and order without necessarily positioning itself as a 'Hindu' party.[70] This is a question that has been at the heart of inner-party debate since the late 1980s. It is now clear that the new BJP has reinvented itself as a part steeped in Hinduness. And this identity politics is too deeply embedded in its